The Digi-Comp II: an illustrated manual

West bay 3: how the Digi-Comp II computes, operation by operation · 27 October 2026

How Babbage's Hall's Digi-Comp II computes, operation by operation: the ones it does now (count, clear, add, multiply, and what follows from them) and the ones still to be built (complement, subtract, divide, AUTO), with the parts each one needs, for anyone who wants to build only some of it.

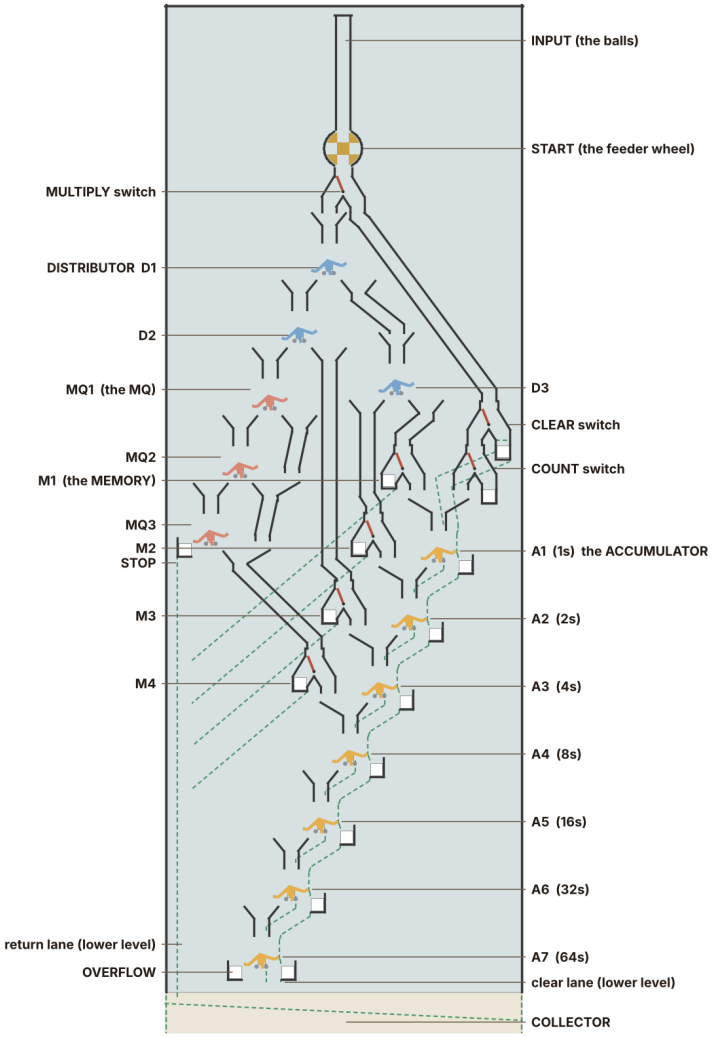
Every picture of the board is drawn from `digicomp2-geometry.lua`, the same numbers the simulation and the printed parts use (`manual/make-figures.sh` redraws them); only the arrows and labels are added. The procedures for the operations still to come are E.S.R.'s, from the original's manual (Evil Mad Scientist's copy: cdn.evilmadscientist.com/KitInstrux/DCII-manual.pdf).

The whole idea in one paragraph. A flip-flop is a rocker that a ball always tips over, and the ball leaves on the side the rocker used to read. Chain them so that a ball leaving one side goes on to the next, and a ball adds one in binary, carrying as it goes: that is the accumulator. Let a set of switches (the memory) choose where balls go into it, and they add a number. Let three flip-flops (the distributor) deal the balls out to those switches in turn, and every four balls add the memory once. Let three more (the MQ) count those turns down, and stop when they run out, and the machine multiplies. Everything else on the board is lanes and holes.

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1. The parts

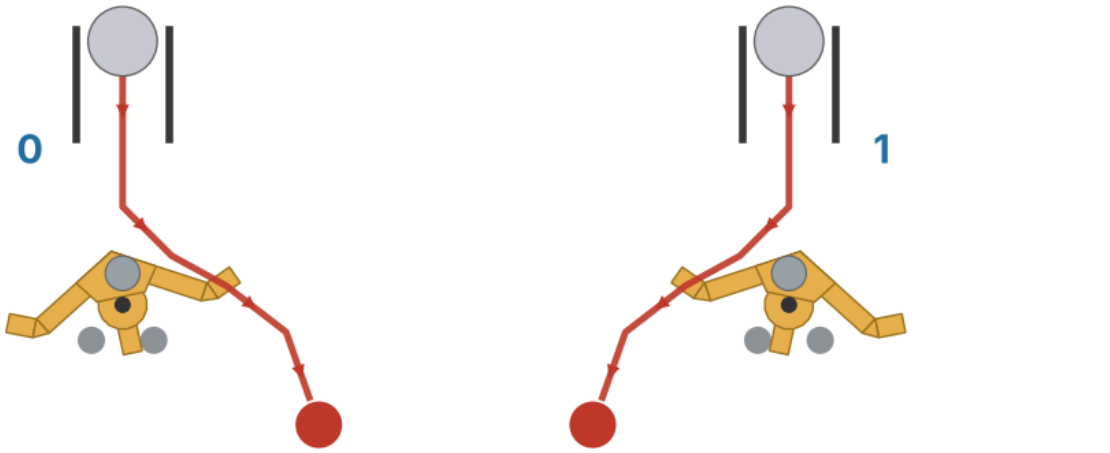


The board, seen from above. The upper plate (blue-grey) carries the balls while they compute; the lower level (dashed green walls) carries finished balls to the collector.

The board slopes toward you at 15 degrees, so a ball let go at the top rolls down it. It has two levels. The balls compute on the **upper plate**. A ball that has finished its work drops through a hole to the **lower level** and rolls under everything else to the **collector** at the bottom. Every ball ends there.

There are only two kinds of moving part, the flip-flop and the switch.

The flip-flop



A flip-flop: found at 0, the ball leaves right and the rocker turns to 1; found at 1, it leaves left and the rocker turns to 0.

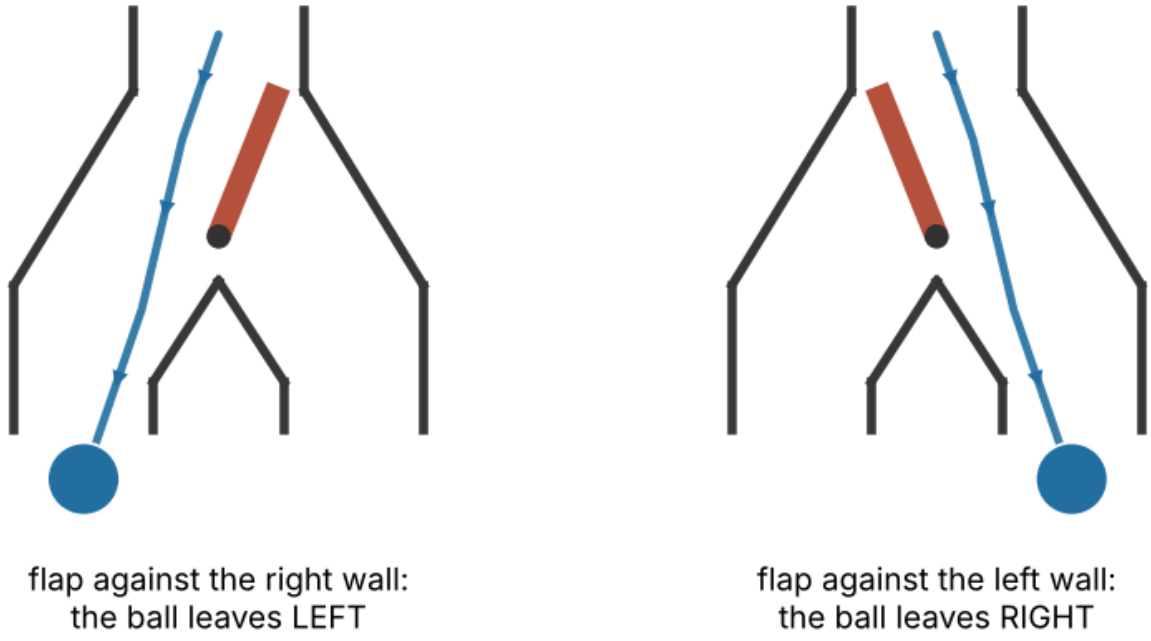
A **flip-flop** is a rocker on a pin: a roof with a cup at each end, a small steel ball pressed in under its apex for weight, and a tail that rests on one of two stop pegs. Its weight sits a little above the pin, so it falls over to one side or the other and stays there. That is one bit of memory: **apex right reads 1, apex left reads 0** (the 0 and 1 are printed on the plate on either side of each apex).

A ball rolling down onto it meets the roof on its raised side, rolls into that side's cup, and its weight tips the rocker over; at the end of the swing the cup tips the ball out. So **every ball flips the rocker**, and **leaves on the side the rocker used to read**:

The rocker read	It now reads	The ball leaves
0	1	to the right
1	0	to the left

That is all a flip-flop does. What it is used for depends on where its two exits lead. All thirteen on this board are the same printed part.

The switch



A switch: the flap closes one outlet; the ball takes the other.

A **switch** is a flap on a pin between two outlets, set by hand. Its free end rests against one wall of the inlet and closes the outlet on that side. A ball only pushes the flap harder against the wall and leaves by the other outlet, so the switch stays as it was set. Each switch has an "on" side, printed on the plate.

The registers and switches

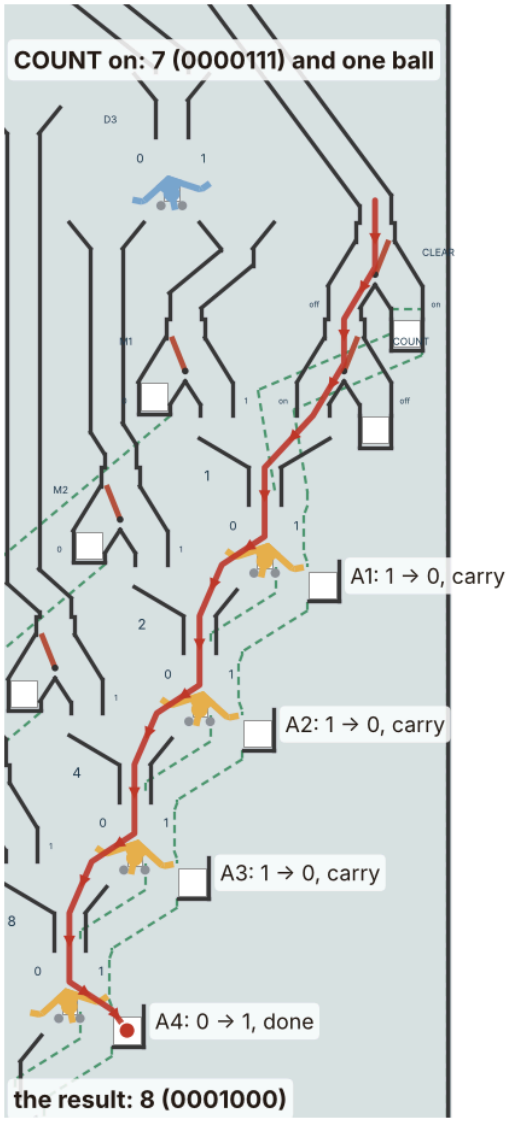
Name	What it is	What it does
START	the feeder: a wheel with four notches under the **INPUT** channel of waiting balls	each quarter turn of its knob lets one ball out
MULTIPLY	a switch	on: the ball goes to the distributor. Off: down to CLEAR
CLEAR	a switch	on: the ball drops into the clear lane. Off: on to COUNT
COUNT	a switch	on: the ball goes into A1. Off: it drops out
A, the accumulator	seven flip-flops, A1 (1s) to A7 (64s)	holds the answer, 0 to 127
M, the memory	four switches, M1 (1s) to M4 (8s)	holds a number, 0 to 15, set by hand
MQ, multiplier-quotient	three flip-flops, MQ1 (1s) to MQ3 (4s)	counts down by one each cycle; 0 to 7
D, the distributor	three flip-flops, D1 to D3	deals the balls out four ways, in turn
STOP	a hole beside MQ3	a ball dropping through it means "finished"
OVERFLOW	a hole beside A7	a carry out of A7 (past 127) drops through it

Reading binary

Each flip-flop of A stands for a power of two: A1 the 1s, A2 the 2s, A3 the 4s, and on to A7, the 64s (the numbers are printed beside them). A number is the sum of the places that read 1. Written the usual way, the 64s first: **0101101** is 32 + 8 + 4 + 1 = **45**. The sign beside the machine shows each register in binary and as a number, but the rockers are the machine's own reading.

2. Counting

Set up: A as you want it (0 to start), MULTIPLY off, CLEAR off, COUNT on. **Then:** START, once for each ball.



Counting: 7 (0000111) and one ball. A1, A2 and A3 each turn 1 to 0 and pass the ball on (the carry); A4 turns 0 to 1 and the ball drops out through A4's hole. The result is 8 (0001000).

The accumulator's flip-flops form a staircase. Each one's **right** exit is a hole to the lower level, so the ball is finished. Its **left** exit runs down into the next flip-flop. So a ball arriving at a flip-flop:

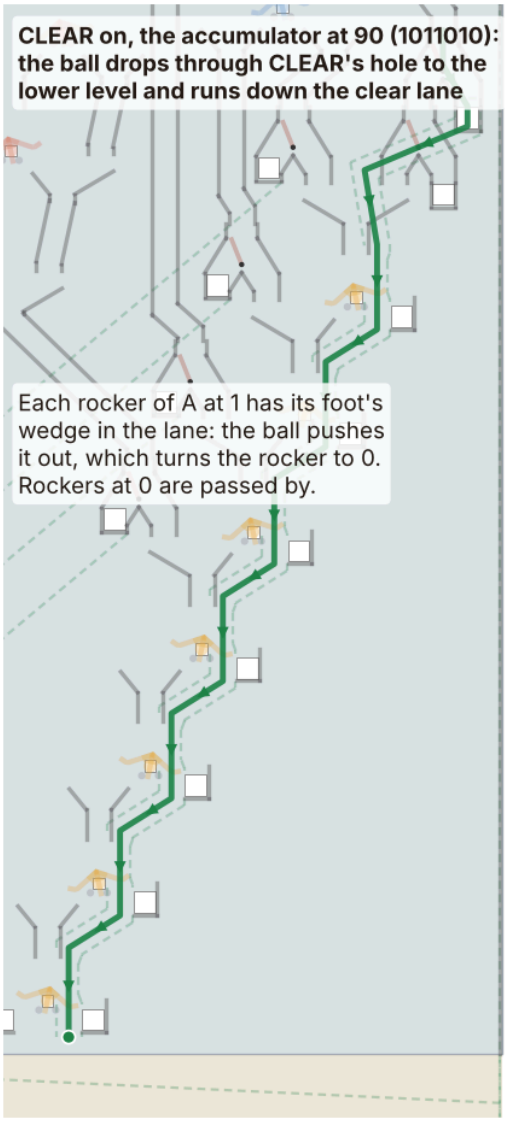
- finds it at **0**: sets it to 1 and drops out. One has been added.
- finds it at **1**: sets it to 0 and goes on to the next flip-flop, which is the **carry** (1 + 1 = 10 in binary).

A ball let into A1 therefore **adds one**, carrying as far as it must. A ball let into A3 adds four, and so on: the memory uses this when it adds.

Overflow. At 127 (1111111) the next ball carries through all seven and out of A7 through the OVERFLOW hole, leaving 0000000.

3. Clearing

Set up: MULTIPLY off, CLEAR on. **Then:** START, one ball.



CLEAR from 90: the ball drops through CLEAR's hole and runs down the clear lane on the lower level, past the foot of each of A's flip-flops.

Under each flip-flop of A, on the lower level, is its **foot**: an arm joined to the rocker through the plate, ending in a wedge. When the rocker reads 1, its wedge leans into the **clear lane**. A ball sent down the clear lane pushes every wedge it meets back out of its way, and pushing the wedge turns the rocker to 0. Rockers already at 0 are passed by. **One ball clears the whole accumulator.**

(You can also clear by hand: set every rocker of A to 0.)

4. Adding

Set up: A = the first number; M = the second (at most 15); MQ = 1; the distributor set to start (D1 = 1, D2 = 1, D3 = 0; key `D`); MULTIPLY on. **Then:** START until a ball drops through STOP: **five balls.**

Adding is a multiply by 1 (section 5): the first four balls add M to A, and the fifth finds the MQ used up and stops. Three things make it work.

The memory. Each memory switch stands beside one of A1 to A4. Set to 1, it sends a ball that reaches it into that flip-flop, which adds 1, 2, 4 or 8 there (with any carry). Set to 0, it drops the ball out. The memory itself never changes.

The distributor deals the balls out in turn. D1 sends them to D2 and D3 alternately, and each of those alternately to its two sides: four balls, four places, then round again. Set to start, the four balls of each cycle go:

Ball of the cycle	Way through the distributor	Then
1st	D1 left, D2 left	through the MQ (one taken away), on to M4
2nd	D1 right, D3 right	M1
3rd	D1 left, D2 right	M3
4th	D1 right, D3 left	M2

So **every four balls add the memory to A once.**

The MQ counts the cycles (section 5).

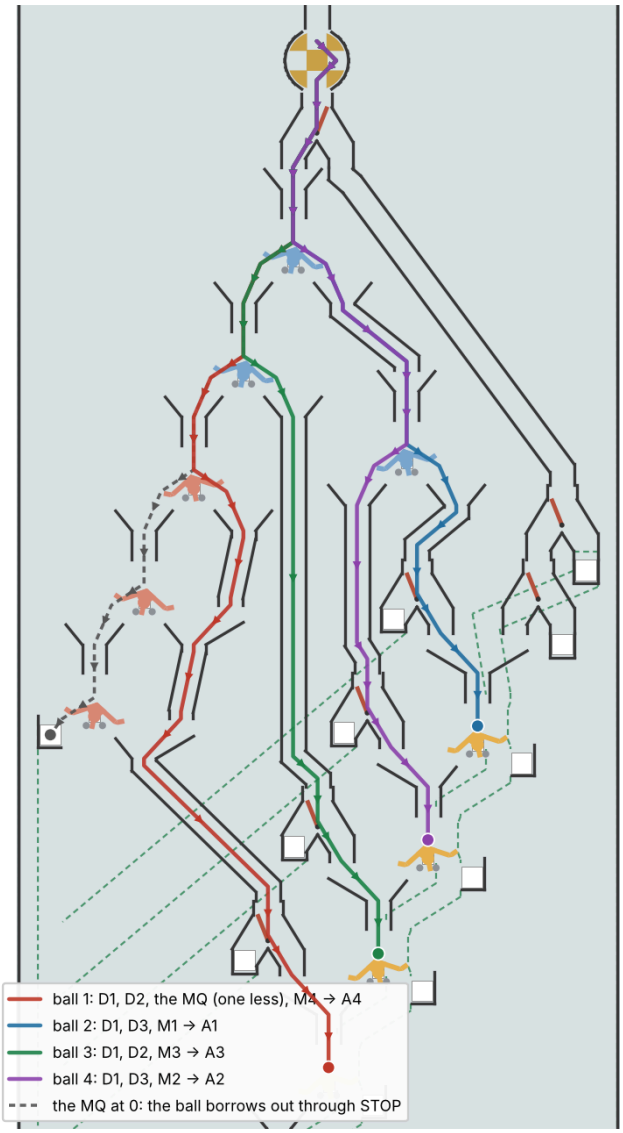
Worked example: 37 + 11 (the tour's). A = 0100101 (37), M = 1011 (11: M4, M2, M1 on; M3 off), MQ = 1:

Ball	Goes to	A after it	MQ after it
1	the MQ (1 to 0), then M4 = 1: adds 8	0101101 = 45	0
2	M1 = 1: adds 1	0101110 = 46	0
3	M3 = 0: drops out	0101110 = 46	0
4	M2 = 1: adds 2 (carries through A2, A3, A4 to A5)	0110000 = 48	0
5	the MQ, at 0: through STOP	**0110000 = 48**	7

Keep the sum at 127 or less (the total passes through OVERFLOW otherwise).

5. Multiplying

Set up: A = 0 (CLEAR it); M = the multiplicand (at most 15); MQ = the multiplier (at most 7); distributor set to start; MULTIPLY on. **Then:** START until a ball drops through STOP: **4 x MQ + 1 balls.**



One cycle of four balls with MULTIPLY on (D1 = 1, D2 = 1, D3 = 0 at the start), and, dashed, the ball that finds the MQ at 0 and leaves through STOP.

Multiplying is adding over and over: every four balls add M to A, and the MQ counts how many times.

The MQ is three flip-flops in a staircase like A's, but it is read the other way round: **1 with the apex to the left** (printed so on the plate). Read that way, a ball through it **takes one away**. A ball that finds an MQ flip-flop at 1 sets it to 0 and leaves to the right, which means done; it runs on to M4. One that finds it at 0 sets it to 1 and goes on to the next, which is the **borrow** (10 - 1 = 01). A borrow out of MQ3 means the MQ was already 0. That ball drops through **STOP**, and the hand (you) stops turning the knob.

Worked example: 13 x 3 (the tour's). M = 1101 (13: M4, M3, M1 on), MQ = 3, A = 0:

Balls	Cycle	A after the cycle	MQ
1 to 4	first: adds 8, 1, 4, 0	13	2
5 to 8	second	26	1
9 to 12	third	39	0
13	the MQ at 0: STOP	**0100111 = 39**	7

Put the smaller number in the MQ: 5 x 7 takes 21 balls with 5 in the MQ, 29 with 7.

What else multiplying does

These need nothing more than the multiply set-up, with different numbers.

- **Multiply and add.** A isn't cleared by MULTIPLY, so whatever is in A is added to: A + M x MQ. Two multiplies in a row add up: 4 x 14, then 5 x 13 without clearing, gives 56 + 65 = **121**.
- **Squaring.** The same number in M and the MQ: 7 x 7 = **49** (29 balls).
- **Shifting.** Multiplying by 2, 4 or 8 moves a number's bits one, two or three places left: put 2, 4 or 8 in M and the number in the MQ, or the number in M and 2 or 4 in the MQ. M = 1101 (13), MQ = 4: **0110100** (52).
- **Decimal to binary** (from E.S.R.'s manual). To find 57 in binary, write it as 5 x 10 + 7: A = 7, M = 10 (1010), MQ = 5. Twenty-one balls later A reads **0111001**. (The MQ's 7 limits this to 79; split bigger numbers, as the original manual does for 123 = 64 + 59.)

6. Still to be built: the complement, subtracting, dividing

These need parts not yet on this board: the **COMPLEMENT** switch, the complement flip-flops **CF1** and **CF2**, six **mode** flip-flops **T1 to T6**, and the **OVERFLOW** switch (RUN or HALT). The procedures below are E.S.R.'s; how the parts will be laid out here is for the next step (2c).

The complement

Subtracting is done by adding a **complement**. The two's complement of a 7-bit number is what you add to it to make 128 (0000000 with an overflow). Turn every bit over (the **ones' complement**), then add one:

	binary	
25	0011001	
every bit turned over	1100110	the ones' complement
plus one	**1100111**	the complement: 103, which is 128 - 25

On the original: A = the number, COMPLEMENT on, START: **four balls.** The mode flip-flops T1 to T6 sit between A's flip-flops. In ADD mode (all left) a carry passes on only when a bit turns from 1 to 0, as in counting. In COMPLEMENT mode (all right) a ball passes every bit and turns each one over. CF1 and CF2 sequence the four balls:

Ball	What it does	A (from 25)
1	sets T1 to T6 to COMPLEMENT mode	0011001
2	passes every bit of A, turning each over	1100110
3	sets T1 to T6 back to ADD mode	1100110
4	adds one	**1100111**

Negative numbers. Read this way, a number whose leftmost bit is 1 is negative: 1100111 is -25. Seven bits hold -64 to +63.

Subtracting

On the original: A = the number to take away; COMPLEMENT on; START (four balls: A now holds its complement). Then MULTIPLY on, COMPLEMENT off, M = the number to take it from, MQ = 1, START (five balls: an add).

Example: 12 - 4. A = 4 (0000100); complement: 1111100 (124). Add M = 12: 124 + 12 = 136, which overflows 128 and leaves **0001000 = 8**. With OVERFLOW on RUN, the overflow is simply lost, which is what makes the complement subtract.

Counting out a number of balls

On the original: A = N; complement it; then COUNT on, OVERFLOW on HALT, and START. A counts up from 128 - N and overflows after exactly **N balls**, and the machine halts. The manual's example counts out nine.

Dividing

Dividing is subtracting over and over, counting how many times: adding the divisor to the dividend's complement until the sum overflows, with the MQ counting the cycles.

On the original: MQ = 111 (7); A = the dividend; M = the divisor; COMPLEMENT on; START (four balls: A holds the dividend's complement). Then COMPLEMENT off, MULTIPLY on, OVERFLOW on HALT, START. Each cycle the distributor adds M to A and takes one from the MQ; when A overflows, the machine halts. The quotient is read from the MQ's **lower numbers**, the other reading of its rockers, which counts up as the upper numbers count down. On this board the plate shows only the upper numbers; the lower are their complement (upper 010 is lower 101).

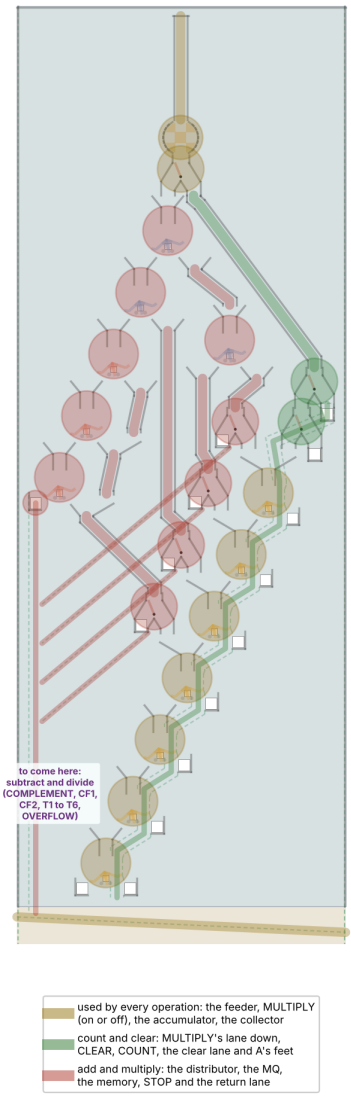
Example: 25 / 5. A = 25, complemented: 103. Then 108, 113, 118, 123 in four cycles, and the fifth reaches 128, which overflows and halts. The MQ was taken from five times: lower numbers **101 = 5**.

The manual's chapter on remainders was not in the copy that could be read here. When the divisor doesn't go exactly (26 / 5, say), counting this way stops one cycle later than the quotient. How the original reads the remainder will be worked out when the complement is built.

Running by itself: AUTO

On the original, AUTO lets a ball reaching the bottom roll under the START lever and release the next ball, so a whole multiply runs by itself. The ball through STOP takes a way that misses the lever, so the machine stops. Here every ball is let in by turning the knob, which is the original's MANUAL. A first try at the lever failed (`FINDINGS.md` says why).

7. Which parts each operation needs



Which parts of this board each kind of operation uses.

Operation	Feeder	A	CLEAR, clear lane	COUNT	MULTIPLY	D, MQ, STOP	M	COMPLEMENT, CF, T	OVERFLOW switch
Count	yes	yes		yes	(off)				
Clear	yes	yes	yes		(off)				
Add	yes	yes			yes	yes	yes		
Multiply, multiply-add, square, shift	yes	yes			yes	yes	yes		
Decimal to binary	yes	yes			yes	yes	yes		
Complement *(to come)*	yes	yes						yes	
Subtract *(to come)*	yes	yes			yes	yes	yes	yes	
Count out N balls *(to come)*	yes	yes		yes				yes	yes
Divide *(to come)*	yes	yes			yes	yes	yes	yes	yes

(MULTIPLY "(off)": on this board every ball passes the MULTIPLY switch on its way down; a board without it would feed CLEAR directly.)

Building only part of it

The steps this machine was built in are each a complete, smaller machine, kept in the repository's history. Each has its own board, tiles, parts list and `make-stls.sh`:

To build	Take	It does	Board
A three-bit counter, one level, balls into bins	step 1 (commit `cb8bb07`)	count to 7	the smallest
The accumulator with START, CLEAR and COUNT, two levels	step 2a (commit `201ee23`)	count to 127, clear	322 × 878 mm, 10 + 10 tiles
Everything so far	this folder (step 2b)	count, clear, add, multiply, and section 5's uses	424 × 1216 mm, 14 + 14 tiles

To get an earlier step's files without changing your checkout:

```
git archive 201ee23 demo/WyomingWill/BabbagesHall/exhibits/DigiComp2 | tar -x -C /some/other/folder
```

Its README lists the parts to print and buy. Some other ways to build less:

- **Without CLEAR**, clear by hand (set every rocker to 0). The feet are part of every rocker either way; the clear lane's walls would have to be taken out of `digicomp2-geometry.lua` to leave them off the lower tiles.
- **Fewer memory bits or a shorter MQ** limit the numbers (M up to 15, MQ up to 7 now). That would need the layout redrawn: it is set in `digicomp2-geometry.lua` and has only been built and tested as it is.
- **For adding only**, the MQ is still needed: it is what stops the fifth ball.

8. Settings at a glance

Operation	A	M	MQ	D	MULTIPLY	CLEAR	COUNT	Balls
Count	start value				off	off	on	one each
Clear					off	on		1
Add A + M	A	M	1	start	on			5
Multiply M x MQ	0	M	MQ	start	on			4 x MQ + 1
Multiply-add A + M x MQ	A	M	MQ	start	on			4 x MQ + 1

On this board, by hand (keys in the simulation): A's rockers `1` to `7`, the memory `H J K L`, the MQ `8 9 0`, the distributor to start `D`, MULTIPLY `M`, CLEAR `C`, COUNT `N`, START `Space`. The tour (`T`) runs counting, clearing, 37 + 11 and 13 x 3.